Nixon stopped in Romania on a similar mission. Washington also turned to Poland and France to mediate with Beijing.

China simultaneously was coming round to the view that the US was less dangerous than the Soviets: the Americans, Mao reasoned, had never occupied Chinese territory. In 1969, fearing war and Soviet military power, a high-ranking PLA generals' committee recommended that it was time to 'play the American card'.[20] In August of that year, when threats of Soviet nuclear strikes against China were rife, Beijing reached out to Washington. The China–US entente climaxed on 9–11 July 1971, in the middle of the East Pakistan crisis. US National Security Advisor (NSA) Henry Kissinger travelled to Pakistan. From there he made his way surreptitiously to China to lay the groundwork for Nixon's famous trip to Beijing in 1972.

India and the USSR align

The trip to China changed the US's stance towards India in one crucial respect. Despite Delhi's difficulties with Washington after 1962, it had always counted on the US as a deterrent against China. After Kissinger's trip to Beijing, it was clear that American strategic interests had pushed it into neutrality in the India–China conflict. Neutrality in effect meant a tilt to China.

Just before the trip, on 6 July, Kissinger had hinted to P.N. Haksar, adviser to Mrs Gandhi, that the US would find itself in an uncomfortable spot if China intervened in an India–Pakistan conflict over the Bangladesh crisis. He also told Jagjivan Ram, India's defence minister, that Washington would 'take a grave view of any Chinese move against India'.[21] However, when he met the Indian ambassador to the US on 17 July, just days after his return from Beijing, he communicated entirely the opposite view, saying categorically, 'we [the US] would be unable to help you against China'.[22] What had changed? In his meetings with Zhou, Kissinger became convinced that China was carefully testing the US commitment to Pakistan: if the US did not stand by Pakistan, would it ever stand by China? Standing